
ACTOR PART BOOK

Player 1

the man with all the hats

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore · Pirandello, trans. Storer 1922

A Village Players production · Lausanne

Director: **Kiarash Jamshidi**

48 SPEECHES · 507 WORDS ACROSS THE PLAY

WHO PLAYER 1 IS

Carries the Leading Man, L'Ingénue, the Door-keeper, the Machinist, and the Third Actor — the largest collection of company roles in the production. **He is in his forties** — old enough to have been promised a career, young enough that the failure still stings fresh, and exactly the wrong age to begin again. The dominant register is the Leading Man, and the Leading Man is the spine of his comedy: vain, faded, defensive, and entirely English in a city that has not given him the career he was promised. He came to Lausanne fifteen years ago, in his late twenties, understanding it was a stepping stone to Paris. Paris did not happen. London does not call. He plays the cards he was dealt — Leading Man at the Village Players, every season — and an increasing share of voice-over work for cantonal radio he does not mention.

His vanity is real. So is the affection beneath it. The vanity shows in the body — the way he holds himself before he speaks, the small grooming gesture before a line he believes is his, the lift of the chin when he thinks the room is watching. He name-drops productions from years ago that nobody remembers, and one production he was *nearly* cast in, which was almost the West End. He says *I have a reputation in this canton*, and on his good days he believes it; on his bad days he says it anyway. He speaks an Anglo English that he thinks of as classical and the audience reads as *English*. He cannot quite remember whether he prefers Pinter or Coward, but he has opinions about both.

The arc to score across the production: he begins Act One in command — the Leading Man with the loudest objection to the cook's cap, the strut, the offence. He spends Act Two being asked to do the old-gallant routine he has spent his career rehearsing, and being laughed at for it by a woman half his age who has actually been through the room he is faking. By Act Three he is one of the Players who would, if he could, go home quietly. The vanity itself never breaks — that is the point — but the audience must see it has stopped protecting him.

He plays five roles, but always as himself. The Leading Man simply puts on different hats. His Door-keeper still has his self-importance. His Machinist still has his opinions. His L'Ingénue is the joke he doesn't quite get is on him. The audience should never feel they are watching five characters; they are watching one man performing his way through five functions, and the same vanity is at the centre of each. He is, in his own estimation, the senior actor in the company — the unofficial spokesman, the one who has the first opinion on every issue, the one whose objections (he believes) speak for everyone. The company tolerates him because he is, occasionally, right.

So the secondary roles are not transformations — they are this man in five hats. The **Door-keeper** is the Leading Man pretending modesty: he lets the wrong six people in and immediately blames the door, the morning, anything but his own judgement. The **Machinist** drops the curtain by mistake at the end of Act Two and looks at it for a long second as if he might apologise to it on tape. **L'Ingénue** is the role he can least pretend to inhabit — half a beat, his real voice slips through, he's gone. The **Third Actor** is whoever the script needs and a chance for the senior actor to demonstrate range. Every transition must be visible — the change of bearing, the lift of the chin, the breath caught a half-beat too long — but underneath the costumes it must remain him. Lean into the Leading Man early. The other four are him with different lighting.

THE PLAY, AND HOW IT BEGINS

What it is. Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921). A theatre company's ordinary rehearsal is interrupted by six figures — a Father, a Mother, a Step-Daughter, a Son, and two silent children — who claim to be unfinished Characters, abandoned by their author, and demand that their drama be staged. The evening is the collision between their fixed, unbearable story and a working company's attempt to turn it into theatre.

This production. Set in Lausanne, played by **nine live performers** with **two stage objects** in place of the two youngest children (a coat-and-chair for the Boy, a wrapped bundle for the Child), on three stripped settings — **no projection, no screen**. One interval, after Act One; the second half plays unbroken to the fountain.

How it opens. The curtain is already up on a half-lit working stage. The Village Players are dragging themselves into a rehearsal of another Pirandello play, *Mixing It Up* — the Manager arrives tired and behind, there is the business of the cook's cap, the Players bicker. Then the working lights soften to a strange amber: the Door-keeper carries in the Boy-chair, and the four family Characters walk on, the Step-Daughter already holding the Child-bundle. From that entrance the play has begun, and it does not let go.

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Everything this role says and does, in performance order, grouped by act and by part. Each speech is preceded by a short **CUE** — the tail of the line before it — so you can find your entrance. Where the role doubles a function, the function is printed beside the line (*as Prompter*, and so on); chorus lines the company speaks together keep their group tag (*All Three Players*). Blocking lives in the bracketed action cues inside the speeches. The text is pulled byte-for-byte from the Director's Copy, so it always matches the current script.

Act One — The Family

PART I *The Rehearsal*

8 SPEECHES · 68 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* ... room? It looks like a waiting room for actors nobody called back.

PLAYER 1 [*settling himself, to no one in particular*]. Then for once we are perfectly cast.

CUE *The Manager:* ... this once, as if you wanted the public back for the third.

PLAYER 1 [*settling himself*]. The public came back for the third act once.

CUE *Player 2:* For you?

PLAYER 1. During me. There's a difference.

CUE *The Manager:* Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. Mime them.

PLAYER 1 [*a small grooming gesture — smoothing the hair before the line*]. Excuse me. Must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?

CUE *The Manager:* It says so there.

PLAYER 1. But it's *ridiculous*. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years of it, and not one inch built on a cook's cap.

CUE *The Manager:* ... So put on the cap, beat the egg, and become the shell.

PLAYER 1. The shell?

CUE *The Manager:* ... whom nobody understands, least of all the people paid to perform him?

PLAYER 1 [*the threat empty; both of them know it*]. I'd sooner resign.

CUE *Player 2:* He resigns every Tuesday.

PLAYER 1 [*settling the cook's cap on his head with the dignity of a man mounting the scaffold*]. Let the record show I wear it under protest.

PART II *The Interruption*

11 SPEECHES · 109 WORDS

PLAYER 1 [*cap in hand — Player 1's diction still visible underneath*]. Excuse me, sir — *désolé* to interrupt; I know you don't like the morning's work disturbed...

CUE *The Manager:* Eh? What is it?

PLAYER 1 [*timidly — but not without a small lift of the chin*]. These people are asking for you, sir. I did tell them you were busy. They insisted.

CUE *Player 3:* Oh — do you hear that?

PLAYER 1 [*stung; it lands because it is half true*]. We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.

CUE *The Manager*: We come here to work, you know.

PLAYER 1. One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of, not before lunch, anyway.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... I can dance and sing. Don't worry — it isn't a hymn.

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3. Bravo! Well done! Encore!

CUE *The Manager*: Silence! This isn't a café concert, you know! Is she mad?

PLAYER 1 *[to Player 2, won over]*. She has more stage presence than the second act. I'll say that.

CUE *The Father*: Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3. Is it true? Has she really fainted?

CUE *The Father*: It's true. It was my doing.

PLAYER 1 *[to the COMPANY, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the MOTHER, and the end of the sentence does not arrive]*. What a spectacle. What an absolute... *[He stops. The treat has gone out of it.]*

CUE *The Manager*: Of course, of course; but let's hear them out.

PLAYER 1 *[the falsetto is half a beat too low; Player 1's voice is showing]*. Most interesting. In a kind of educational way.

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: ... — a regular customer of Madame Pace's shop. A very regular customer.

PLAYER 1 *[shifting in his seat, eyes down — quiet now, almost ashamed; not a punchline]*. — These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

CUE *The Father*: ... there at all. That is the only difference between us. That's all.

PLAYER 1 *[under his breath, to Player 3]*. I have several questions. None of them are polite.

PART III *The Bargain*

4 SPEECHES · 41 WORDS

CUE *The Manager*: Yes, yes. Come on! come on! Be punctual, please!

PLAYER 1. Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

CUE *Player 2*: No. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed.

PLAYER 1. And now he wants us to make a play out of them. In twenty minutes.

CUE *Player 2*: ... The question is whether anyone is being paid to be in it.

PLAYER 1 (AS DOOR-KEEPER) *[the cap forgotten in his hand; Player 1's posture leaking through the doorman's apology]*. I only let them in.

CUE *Player 2*: That is not a defence.

PLAYER 1. They looked expected.

Act Two — The Theatre

PART I *The Setup*

6 SPEECHES · 47 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* Come on, come on, ladies and gentlemen! Right — you there, machinist!

PLAYER 1 *[two words; somehow still managing to deliver them as a Leading Man].* Yes, sir.

CUE *The Manager:* Don't worry! You won't have to improvise.

PLAYER 1. What do we do, then — sit and applaud?

CUE *The Manager:* I can assure you it would be a magnificent spectacle!

PLAYER 1 *[dry now, the joke costing him something].* What is the use of us here, then? Furniture with opinions?

CUE *The Father:* ... that I am to be acted by... I don't know by whom...

PLAYER 1 *[on his dignity — chin lifted, the bearing arranged].* By me, if you've no objection.

CUE *The Father:* ... all his good will and wonderful art, to absorb me into himself...

PLAYER 1 *[the dignity cracking].* Oh — come off it. "Wonderful art." He says it like he means it. Withdraw that, please.

CUE *The Father:* ... be so good as to give me their hats for a moment...

PLAYER 1 *[half surprised, half laughing].* Our hats?

PART II *The Apparition*

4 SPEECHES · 42 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* What sort of a trick is this?

PLAYER 1 *[almost at the same time — a hand pressed flat to his chest, as if checking he is still there].* What's going to happen next? Have we lost the script entirely?

CUE *The Manager:* Well? well?

PLAYER 1 *[cupping a hand to his ear, the bearing of a man used to being heard at the back of the house].* What does she say? Madame — speak up.

CUE *The Father:* ... hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

PLAYER 1 *[interrupting — protective of the company's property, the senior actor surfacing through the wig].* I say... those are *our* hats, you know.

CUE *The Manager:* Have a little patience! Of course, it must be treated rather lightly.

PLAYER 1. Still — with a bit of go in it. Which I, of course, will provide.

PART III *The Substitution*

CUE *Player 2:* Of course. It's easy enough. Shall you and I try it now?

PLAYER 1. Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance. *[Exit to make his entrance.]*

CUE *The Manager:* ... You'll be able to learn something. Come on! come on! Entrance, please!

PLAYER 1. Good afternoon, Miss...

CUE *The Manager:* Nonsense! Rubbish! Stand aside and let me see the action.

PLAYER 1 *[the practised gallantry already in his shoulders before he speaks].* If I've got to play an old man walking into a place of — shall we say — *equivocal character*, and we all know what we mean, then at the very least let me find the door.

CUE *The Manager:* ... to them, for Heaven's sake! Do it again! It goes fine. Well?

PLAYER 1. Good afternoon, Miss.

CUE *Player 2:* Good afternoon.

PLAYER 1 *[imitating the gesture of the FATHER when he looked under the hat, and then expressing quite clearly first satisfaction and then fear].* Ah, but... I say... this is not the first time that you have come here, is it?

CUE *Player 2:* No, sir.

PLAYER 1. You've been here before, more than once.

CUE *The Manager:* Go on!

PLAYER 1. You've been here before, eh? Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

CUE *Player 2:* No sir... I'll do it myself.

PLAYER 1 *[a step closer, practised gallantry].* Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

CUE *Player 2:* No thank you, sir.

PLAYER 1 *[the smile he has used a thousand times].* Oh come now — you must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There's always a way round these little matters, you know.

CUE *Player 2:* ... because I am — as you see — you might have noticed.

PLAYER 1 *[a beat, then deeply gallant].* ...in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm frightfully sorry.

CUE *Player 2:* ... been made a fool of — believe me — by considerably better.

PLAYER 1 *[two steps toward the exit — then a calculation crosses his face; he stops].* Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

Act Three — The Question

PART I *The Trap*

2 SPEECHES · 18 WORDS

┆ **CUE** *The Manager*: ... — we can't change scenes three or four times in one act.

PLAYER 1. They used to change scenes like that once. When theatres had more hands than rules.

┆ **CUE** *The Manager*: ... I tell you, sir, which we've got to create for the audience...

PLAYER 1. With our acting.

PART II *The Refusal*

1 SPEECH · 8 WORDS

┆ **CUE** *The Father*: ... call it human. Let me ask why, and suddenly it is forbidden.

PLAYER 1 [*low, to Player 3*]. I would like to go home. Quietly. Now.

PART III *The Fountain*

1 SPEECH · 3 WORDS

┆ **CUE** *The Manager*: Is he really wounded?

PLAYER 1 & PLAYER 3. He's dead! dead!